OTT ▼

PRINCELY WHIRLS

Netflix's The Royals is a heady romance replete with lavish balls and the aroma of aristocracy



IN BLUE BLOOD **Ishaan Khatter and Bhumi Pednekar star in *The Royals***

Romcoms are a rare breed in Indian streaming. Producer and creator Rangita Pritish Nandy is aware of the dearth of the feelgood, fun love story and hopes to fix it with *The Royals*, a Netflix series which follows the growing attraction between Bhumi Pednekar, playing a go-getter entrepreneur, and Ishaan Khatter as a reluctant crown prince. "We don't live in a simple world anymore," says Nandy, talking about why the genre is overlooked. "Everything on OTT is at a certain decibel level. To do the easy decibel space is tough." Romcoms are perceived as smaller in the larger scheme of things, but Netflix dished out a royal treatment, allowing Nandy and her team "to dream", be it in scale or set-pieces (yes, there's a ball!).

Writer Neha Veena Sharma researched India's "fading royalty"—reading books and interviewing young and old royals to bring authenticity. In fact, the character of Maaji sa (Zeenat Aman) came from meeting royals at a soiree. "When I asked a young woman what she did, her mother replied, 'Oh darling, we don't do, we just be'." It inspired a memorable line Aman renders in the teaser and which went viral on social media. "Yes, they are like Disney princes and princesses within a makebelieve world, but there's also culture, tradition, legacy and a connection to people. It's not always about money. We didn't want to just laugh with and at [the royals] but also love, engage and get to know them," says Nandy.

Comparisons with Netflix's "royal romcom" *Bridgerton* are inevitable and Nandy ensured the show didn't feel like a "poor country cousin". The women-fronted team—the two directors, director of photography, costume designer, production designer and dialogue writer are all women—helped her realise her vision for contemporary royalty in India.

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"The '*haan ho jayega, ban jayega* (will be done, will be made)' vibe terrifies me," says Nandy. "When it came down to details and aesthetics, I found the collaboration with women more fulfilling and easier. We rallied together and worked together."

Romcoms may be outnumbered by crime thrillers on OTT, but Nandy notes that platforms are eager to greenlight stories in the genre. "Netflix asked us to make this show," she says. "They know this is a genre that's about to burst. Every time I meet Tanya [Bami, series head, Netflix], she's like 'Hey, you have another one?' There's not enough minds who think romcoms are serious and relevant enough, and not enough creators." With *The Royals*, Nandy has left no stone unturned to create one. There's a peppy soundtrack, lavish spreads, a cast dressed to the nines and, more importantly, a shirtless prince and a damsel who calls the shots. ■

—Suhani Singh